Ask for the event, then follow the decisions

Interview questions that leave room for a different explanation.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE

TRIGGER

What started the task?

Find the situation and the information needed.

→

DECISION

What did you try next?

Follow the action and the workaround.

→

RESULT

How did you know it was done?

Find the actual completion condition.

Start with a recent occurrence.

Use a specific task. Give the person time to recall what happened before asking for their opinion.

PREDICTION

Would you use a team dashboard?

The answer may describe an intention or respond to the idea you just introduced.

RECALL

Tell me about the last time you assigned a request.

A recent event gives you actions, information and decisions to ask about.

Follow the information, not your feature.

When they mention a tool or message, ask what they needed from it. Keep the proposed solution out of the question.

01

TRIGGER

What started the task?

Find the situation and the information needed.

↓

02

DECISION

What did you try next?

Follow the action and the workaround.

↓

03

RESULT

How did you know it was done?

Find the actual completion condition.

Replace questions that announce the answer.

A follow-up should help the person explain the event. It should not recruit agreement for a design.

Leading question	Event-based question
Was the dashboard confusing?	What were you looking for on this screen?
Would alerts solve that?	How did you find out that the request had changed?
Do you need better filters?	How did you decide which requests to open?
Would you pay for this feature?	What do you use now, and what does that cost you?

Keep the finding narrower than the story.

Hypothetical finding: the lead asks a teammate for current capacity before assignment.

Possible explanations include missing visibility, unreliable data or a rule that needs human judgement.

Observed behaviour

Record the action and the context.

Competing explanations

Write at least one plausible alternative cause.

Next check

What could distinguish those explanations?